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Abstract

There have been a lot of changes with the automotive industry and the new connected technologies. Smart vehicles have been able to use new technologies to improve user experience and operation efficiencies, but with these improvements come new and dangerous cyber threats. One of the examples of how unsecure automotive technologies can endanger both businesses and the public is the 2015 hacking of the Jeep Cherokee. Hackers were able to take control of a moving Jeep Cherokee by exploiting the connect system. There were also a lot of public concerns surrounding the automotive technologies. Unsecured control of automotive systems was also very concerning to the public's and societies claim to the privacy regarding the technologies.

This report will analyse the hacking incident within the context of the social, legal, ethical, and professional areas of concern. In the social context, the incident showcases the danger to the public and the breach of trust that comes with the use of interconnected devices. Responsible disclosure, or ethical hacking, was first proposed by Sir Timothy Berners-Lee as a way to grant better control and secure technologies. This event triggers the ethical side of the legal cyber security, negligence, and product safety, which, in turn, outlines the legal area of the incident. From a professional standpoint, the hacking incident illustrates the user-oriented system design and the necessity of safety within the design of intelligent control systems.

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1 INTRODUCTION AND BACKGROUND OF THE SCANDAL

1.1 Introduction of the company



Figure 1: Figure of Remote car-jacking of Jeep Cherokee.

The multinational automotive company Fiat Chrysler Automobiles (FCA) originated from the 2014 merger between Fiat S.p.A. of Italy and Chrysler Group of the United States. At the time of the 2015 Jeep Cherokee hacking incident FCA operated as one of the world major automobile manufacturers which produced popular brands including Jeep and Dodge and Chrysler and Ram. The company became part of Stellantis through its merger with PSA Group.

The 2014 Jeep Cherokee showed FCA's cutting-edge vehicle technology through its connected vehicle system. The vehicle included the Uconnect infotainment system which provided features such as navigation and entertainment and Bluetooth connectivity and hands-free communication through a cellular internet connection. The smart features provided better user convenience and vehicle performance but they created security problems because they connected the vehicle's internal networks to outside networks (Gibbs, 2015).

The Uconnect system enabled the vehicle to establish internet communication through a cellular network which allowed users to access the system remotely. The researchers Charlie Miller and Chris Valasek used this security flaw in 2015 to prove that people could control essential vehicle functions which included steering and braking and transmission from a distance without needing to enter the vehicle. (Kaliraj, 2023).

1.2 Introduction to cyber threats and risks



Figure 2: Figure of Cyber Threats and risks

A cybersecurity threat can be defined as any action intentional or unintentional that compromises the security of an organization or an individual. As threats grow and evolve, organizations need to understand what they are up against: it's the only way to defend against cybersecurity threats from criminals who exploit vulnerabilities to gain access to your networks, data, and confidential information.

Security operations have become an indispensable aspect of organizational survival and success. Cyberattacks and data breaches regularly make headlines as malicious actors continue to adapt and develop new tactics (Regalado, 2024).

1.3 Common Cybersecurity threats

1.3.1 Malware



Figure 3: Figures of Malware.

Malware refers to any software whose purpose is to attack the computer, utilize its components, extract data from the computer, or damage the computer. Types of malware include virus, trojan,

ransomware, and spyware. Malware serves different purposes depending on the type. Some malware is highly advanced and difficult to detect. The main modes of malware infections include downloading unknown files from untrusted websites or from interacting with infected computers.

1.3.2 Man in the middle (MITM) attacks (aka on-path attacks)

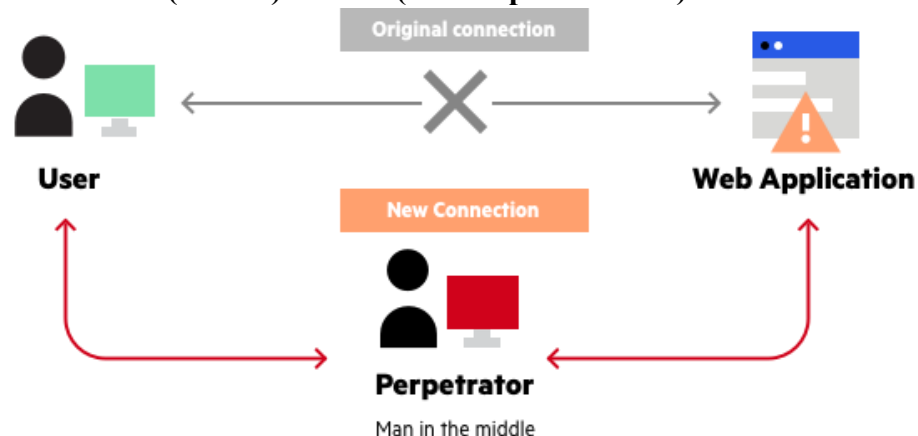


Figure 4: Figures of (MITM) attack.

In MITM or on-path attacks, threat actors intercept the communication between two parties to steal sensitive information or alter the data passed from one party to another. MITM attacks are commonly seen on public networks. In MITM, attackers can also impersonate a party to trick the other party into believing that they're talking to a legitimate party. MITM attacks are usually used to steal individual sensitive information such as credentials, credit card details, etc., for identity theft or malicious transactions. However, they can also be used to breach an enterprise.

2 Background of the Scandal

2.1 Overview of the incident

The cybersecurity of vehicles is increasingly more threatened as vehicles become more connected. Phones can be connected to the vehicle's entertainment system, the entertainment system itself could be connected to the Internet to download the latest hits or new updates, the vehicle's navigation requires GPS input, and so on. New technologies, enabling vehicles to take over the driving task partially or entirely (e.g. automated vehicles), require the vehicle to communicate with the infrastructure around it (V2I communication), with vehicles around it (V2V communication) and/or with other elements outside the vehicle (V2X communication) (Dietmar P.F. Moller, 2019).

2.2 Who Was Involved?

The second individual who needs special attention in this case study is Charlie Miller and Chris Valasek, researchers focused on issues pertaining to cybersecurity. They are recognized as dependable sources of information regarding cybersecurity of vehicles since they have conducted research about the problems faced by vehicles owing to advancements in technology. The primary purpose of conducting research by both Charlie and Chris was to determine whether any vulnerabilities existed in the car's cybersecurity system that could force automobile companies to make cybersecurity systems of cars stronger prior to launching a cyber-attack on the vehicle.

In this case study, the vehicle under consideration is a 2014 Jeep Cherokee made by Fiat Chrysler Automobiles (FCA). It features an internet-connected infotainment system called "Uconnect." (Vellinga, 2022).

2.3 How the Vehicle Was Hacked

In this particular case, the attackers used the vulnerability in the Uconnect infotainment system. This system was connected to the internet using a cellular network. This means that attackers could identify the IP address of the car in question and use it to bypass all the security elements of the system and gain remote access to the car's network.

Through gaining access to the car's network, the hackers were able to take control over a number of systems in the vehicle. Initially, the hackers controlled such non-critical components as the radio, air conditioner, and the windshield wipers. But later, the hackers were able to gain control over much more important systems including the car's engine, transmission system, brakes, and steering wheel (Shahida Malik, 2020).

2.4 Why the Incident Was Important

Jeep Cherokee hacking is particularly important since it brought to light the dangers which may arise from the connected car technology. This is unlike cyber hacking attacks which only focus on stealing money or information; the possibility of causing tangible damage due to connected car technology was now clear to all.

The issue is especially of public safety and privacy issues as well as lack of trust in the emerging smart technology for cars. It also showed how risky it can be to interconnect critical systems to internet communication networks without having adequate security measures in place. The

potential consequences in case of an attack would have been deadly including road accidents among other things.

3 SOCIAL ISSUES

3.1 Background of Social Issues

High-tech advancements have improved communication, travel, and general convenience. Smart cars have high-tech advancements to guide the driver, entertain, and do many other things, making driving easier. However, cyber threats exist in advanced technology because of exploitation.

Hacking of 2015 Jeep Cherokee is an excellent instance that shows how cybercrime exposes society to danger through cybercrime targeting smart cars. Miller and Valasek successfully controlled features of the car from afar, creating anxiety regarding security on IoT devices. The incident created cybersecurity concerns about the Internet of Things technologies and generated fear, lack of trust, and privacy concerns among the masses. (Ryan, 2019).

3.2 Public Safety Risk

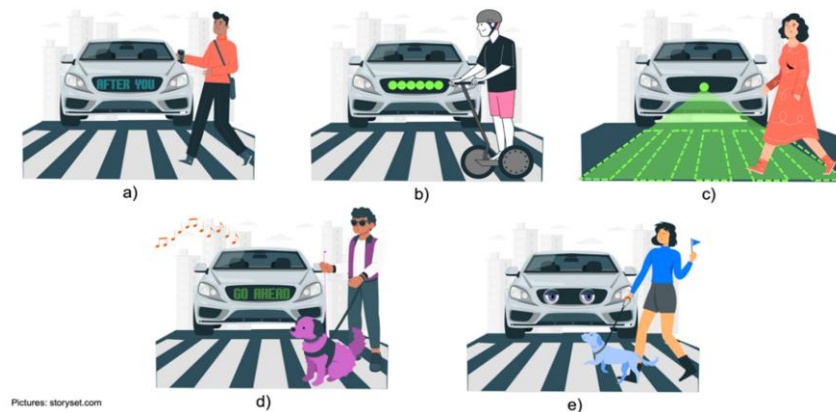


Figure 5: Figure of Public Safety Risk in connected vehicle.

Some of the main social implications that have emerged from the case where hackers remotely took control of the Jeep Cherokee are related to safety. The fact that one can hack into the computer in the car and control some basic operations such as acceleration, braking, and turning the car is very dangerous. If such attacks happen while the car is on the road, it increases the risk of accidents that will not only result in the damage of property, but in the worst-case scenario, death. The risk not only affects the people in the car, but it poses danger to third parties including other cars and pedestrians who are involved (Martínez-Buelvas, 2025).

3.3 Fear and Anxiety Among Users

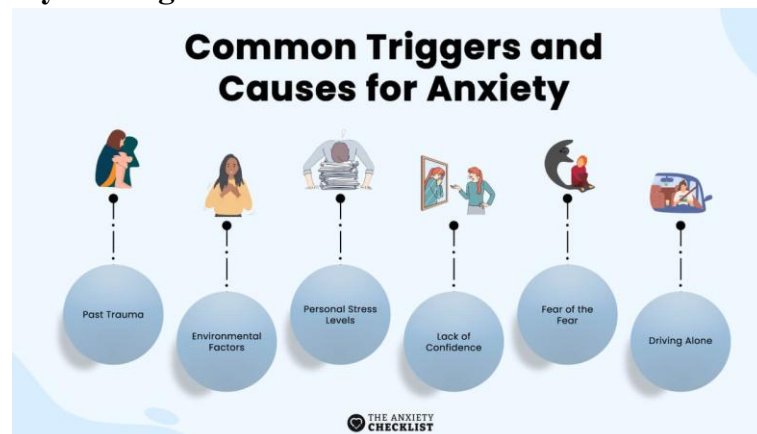


Figure 6: Figures of Fear and Anxiety Among User.

The security issue experienced by Jeep Cherokee users was quite alarming among them due to the vulnerability of smart cars shown by this particular incident. Users were frightened about security issues and became wary of the capabilities of their car to serve them efficiently due to its vulnerability to cyber-attacks. Mistrusts such as this often make consumers avoid a product that could be considered too risky to use. The possibility of a security threat arising at any point in time when one uses the car also puts additional pressure on the user's mind regarding his safety when driving the car (Meinlschmidt, 2023).

3.4 Loss of Trust in Technology

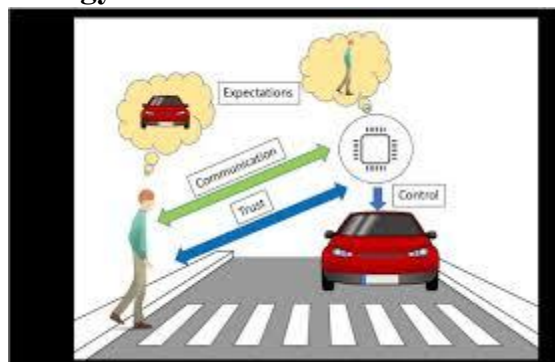


Figure 7: Figure of Loss Trust in Technology.

The hacking of the Jeep Cherokee was one of the events which led to reduced faith in technology and specifically connected cars among users. It is quite clear that whenever users were aware of the fact that remote access was possible into their car, they began questioning the benefits of using such a technology. It is true that users had high hopes when it comes to technology since they

believed that it would provide more security to them. However, with the help of this hacking incident, it was proved that there were some drawbacks related to technology as well (Mengel, 2025).

3.5 Privacy Concerns



Figure 8: Figure of Privacy Concerns in connected vehicle.

- The connected cars generate data that contains sensitive information of the users such as location, driving patterns, and personal details.
- There is always a possibility that hackers might be able to hack into these systems and gain access to the sensitive data.
- The stolen data can be used for tracking or committing various fraudulent acts.
- There is always a risk of compromising on user data due to lack of proper safeguards.
- This poses the question of how secure the information of users remains within the company (Santis, 2025).

3.6 Negative Impact on Society and Economy

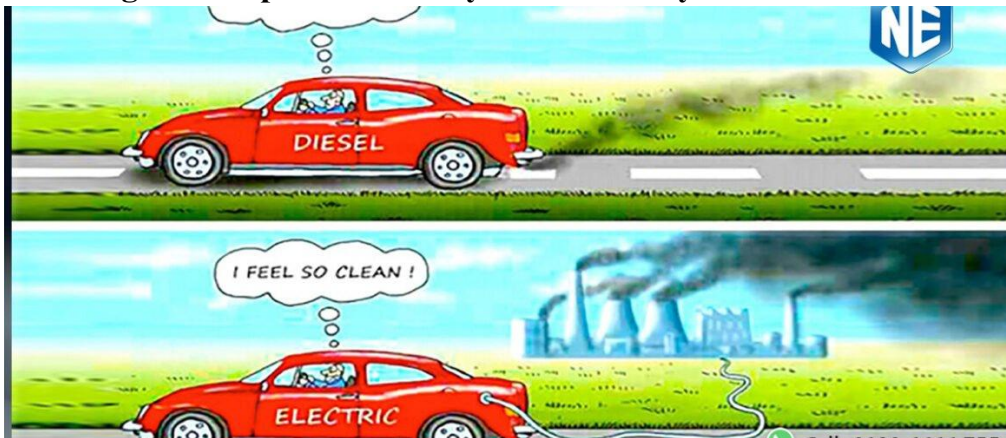


Figure 9: Figure of Negative impact on Society and Economy.

Connected vehicles bring many benefits, but they also create serious risks for society and the economy if they are attacked or misused (Klaver, 2021).

Table 1: Table of Negative Impact on society and Economy.

Social Impact	Economic Impact
Violation of Privacy	Financial Losses
Safety Issues	Maintenance and Security Expenses
Loss of Confidence	Increase in Insurance Fees
Fear and worry	Reputation Damage
Identity Thief and Misuse of Personal Information	Disruptions in Business Activities

4 ETHICAL ISSUES

4.1 Background of Ethical Issues



Figure 10: Figures of Ethical Issues in connected vehicle.

Ethical concerns in cybersecurity involve deciding between right and wrong behaviour concerning the use of technology and management of digital systems. Ethical issues become even more important in connected vehicles as cyberattacks pose significant risks that include harm to people. The professionals and experts involved in finding and disclosing vulnerabilities need to behave ethically.

Questions emerged in the case of the 2015 Jeep Cherokee hacking incident related to disclosure practices and the morals of both the developers and the experts. While they exposed severe problems for the sake of better protection and security in order to ensure safety, they had accessed the vehicle without permission and controlled its functions remotely. Consequently, an issue of ethicality came up.

There are several ethical theories, such as Utilitarianism, Deontology, and Virtue Ethics, which are used to assess a case. Each of them determines if certain actions are moral or immoral. (Aguinaga, 2020).

4.2 Unauthorized Access to Systems

The hacking into the Jeep Cherokee vehicle system by the researchers was done without consent from the manufacturer to prove the flaw. Using Utilitarianism ethics, the act would be justified because it was for the good of all as it would prevent criminals from using such flaws once they were identified. The researchers violated ethical standards in this scenario as per Deontology since they did not follow the set rules and invaded someone's privacy.

4.3 Endangering Human Lives

The scientists operated functions like steering, braking, and acceleration through remote controls during the experiment, thus posing dangers to the life of the person inside the vehicle.

Utilitarianism can be used to support the risk since the study could help stop further attacks in the future. However, Deontology is clear in its assertion that actions, which pose risks to people's safety, should never have been undertaken irrespective of the results. From Virtue Ethics, it is not morally right to expose oneself to danger through experiments.

4.4 Responsible Disclosure vs Public Exposure

Table 2: Table of Responsible Disclosure vs Public Exposure.

Aspect	Responsible Disclosure	Public Exposure
Meaning	Informing the company about security issues without releasing it publicly	Releasing security vulnerability information to the public or media
Purpose	To enable time to solve the problems before hacker's attack	To raise awareness of the security vulnerabilities
Risk Level	The risk level is relatively low to end-users since there are chances to resolve the problem	The risk level is relatively high as hackers can attack the system
Impact on Security	Positive impact on security as the company can solve the problem in a safe manner	Negative impact on security because it may result in a security threat
Ethical View	An ethical practice of responsible disclosure in security	practices Not an ethical practice
Example in Jeep Incident	Informed Jeep first before disclosing information on vulnerabilities Disclosed	Information on vulnerabilities and how to hack the car

4.5 Negligence of Manufactures

This event pointed out the ethical obligation for manufacturing companies to develop security systems for connected cars. The theory of utilitarianism implies that enhancing cybersecurity will serve societal needs by ensuring that users are safe from any cyber-attacks. In terms of deontological ethics, there is an obligation for manufacturing companies to ensure the safety and privacy of their customers.

4.6 Misuse of Technical Knowledge

The technical skills related to cybersecurity may be applied both for the right reasons and for wrong purposes. Here, in this case, the researchers have made use of their technical knowledge to find out any weaknesses in the system, but there was no intention of self-interest here. If we look at the concept of ethical hacking within the utilitarian approach, it can be considered as ethically correct as long as it helps achieve good cybersecurity and keeps people safe. In the deontological approach, the use of technical knowledge should not involve any wrong purposes at all.

5 LEGAL ISSUES

5.1 Background of legal Issues

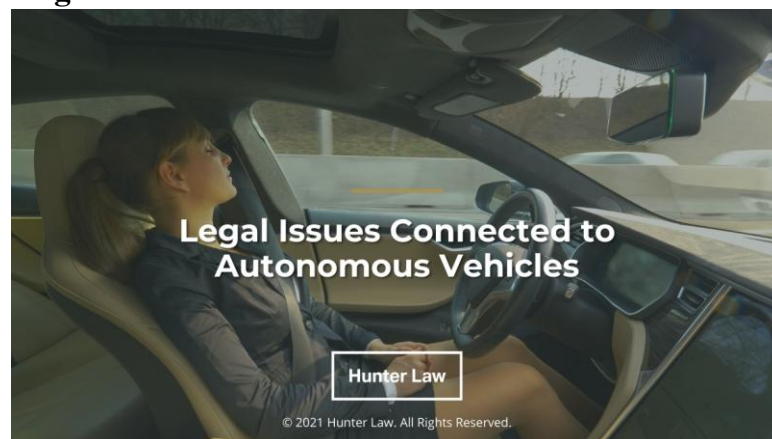


Figure 11: Figure of Legal Issues in connected vehicle.

Legal problems in cybersecurity consist of the regulation governing the usage of technology systems and cybersecurity protection practices. Legal issues in connected vehicles involve the enactment of cyber laws which regulate the safety and protection of the technology systems, the confidentiality of the users' information, and legal accountability for cybersecurity protection during system designs. Some of the legal issues involving connected vehicles include misuse of computers, accountability and liability issues, and safety laws which regulate the compliance with safety and cybersecurity measures by vehicles.

There is legal dilemma in relation to the 2015 hacking incident which involved accessing the system of a Jeep Cherokee remotely for the purpose of vulnerability research on cyber laws. (Sas, 2018).

5.2 Unauthorized Access and Computer Misuse

Unauthorized access to any automotive system may breach cyber-crime laws like computer misuse laws. It does not matter whether the researcher intends to conduct research because even then the act will be regarded as criminal. Nevertheless, the researcher can avoid any form of prosecution (Lancaster, 2021).

5.3 Violation Of Vehicle Safety Regulations

Vehicle connectivity is subject to compliance with strict safety guidelines. Failure to protect against remote control by an insecure vehicle system poses the risk of failing to meet the minimum safety requirements.

5.4 Product Liability

According to product liability laws, any damages incurred due to defects in design or protection of the product will place responsibility on the manufacturer. Therefore, where a cyber-attack results in an accident or injury, liability lies with the manufacturer.

5.5 Negligence by Manufactures

A company will be regarded as being negligent if it fails to incorporate cybersecurity. In cases where negligence has been proved to cause any form of damage to the user, a lawsuit can arise.

5.6 Law Involved in connected vehicles (Legal Perspective)

Table 3: Table of Law Involved in Connected Vehicles.

Legal Area	Explanation	Application in Connected Vehicles	Impact
Cybercrime Laws	Laws that prevent illegal access, hacking, and misuse of digital systems.	Protects vehicle systems like GPS, braking, and user data from unauthorized access or malware.	Punishes hackers and protects vehicle security.
Product Safety Laws	Laws ensuring products are safe and free from harmful defects.	Requires manufacturers to secure both hardware and software in connected vehicles.	Leads to recalls, fines, or lawsuits if safety is compromised.
Data Protection Laws	Protects personal data from misuse or unauthorized access.	Secures driving data, location, and user information in connected systems.	Prevents privacy breaches and enforces penalties.
Liability Laws	Defines who is responsible when damage or failure occurs.	Assigns responsibility to manufacturers or developers if cyberattacks cause harm.	Enables compensation and legal action.
Regulatory Compliance	Rules and standards companies must follow for safety and security.	Ensures vehicles meet cybersecurity and safety standards before release.	Non-compliance leads to fines or product bans.

6 PROFESSIONAL ISSUES

6.1 Introduction to Profession and Professionals

Cybersecurity experts and software engineers contribute greatly towards creating and managing secure systems. It is their job not only to create software that works but to make sure that their users' lives remain safe, secure, and reliable. In the context of connected cars, there are ethical obligations to fulfil as any failure or insecurity can affect people's lives.

6.2 Background of Professional Issues

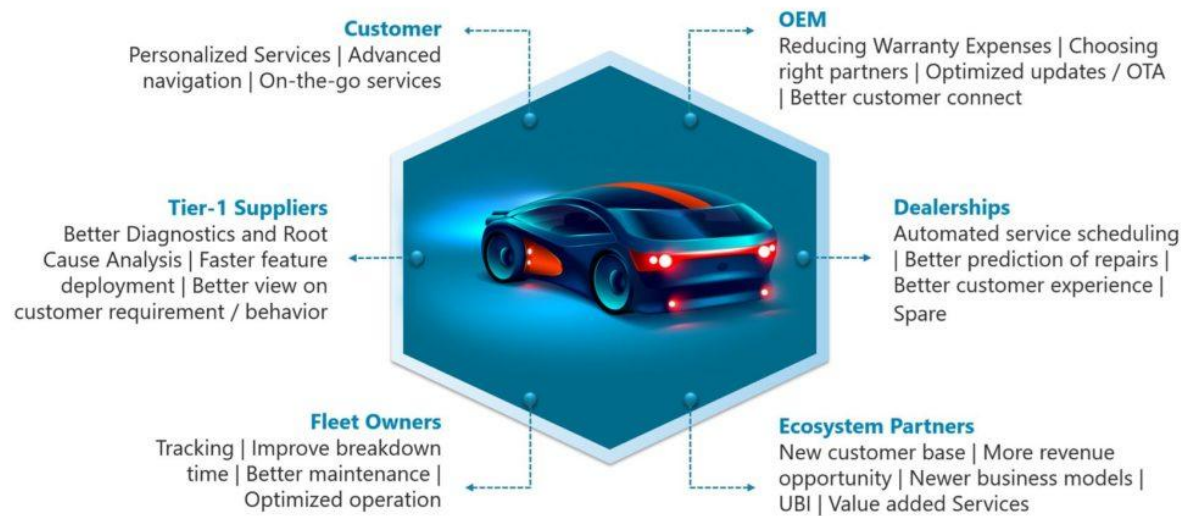


Figure 12: Figure of Professional issues in connected vehicle.

Problems among professionals come when they don't adhere to the codes of ethics set out for them, or when what they do causes ethical problems. In the Jeep Cherokee hack of 2015, professionals exhibited responsible conduct and irresponsible conduct. They uncovered vital security flaws, but how they accessed the computer brought up questions concerning the codes of ethics for professionals like ACM, IEEE, and BCS. (Bécsi, Aradi, & Gáspár, 2015).

6.3 Violation of ACM Code of Ethics

The ACM Code of Ethics says that a computer scientist has the obligation not to inflict harm on others and to uphold privacy. In this particular case, gaining unauthorized access to the vehicle is an infraction of this moral code, despite the intention to enhance security. Nonetheless, the ACM promotes public safety too.

6.4 Failure to Prioritize Public Safety

IEEE Code of Ethics emphasizes the importance of giving priority to safety. The remote control of the functionalities such as stop and steer could cause risks to safety in the performed experiment. This is a dilemma since it causes a conflict between the purposes of the study and safety for the users.

6.5 Professional Responsibility of Developers

As per the codes of conduct established by ACM, IEEE, and BCS, the duty of designing secure and dependable systems falls upon developers. From the above case study, it is clear that the producers were negligent in ensuring security within the system of the car.

6.6 Responsible Vulnerability Disclosure

The BCS Code of Conduct stresses the importance of being honest and responsibly reporting security problems. The authors of this study adhered to the principle of responsible disclosure, as they notified the producer prior to publishing their findings.

6.7 Accountability and Transparency

Table 4: Table of Accountability and transparency.

Code of Ethics	Accountability	Transparency	Application in Connected Vehicles
ACM Code of Ethics	Professionals must take responsibility for their work and its consequences.	Requires honesty in reporting issues and disclosing risks clearly.	Developers and researchers must report vehicle vulnerabilities properly and accept responsibility for security flaws.
IEEE Code of Ethics	Engineers are responsible for ensuring public safety and the outcomes of their designs.	Engineers should be open about limitations, risks, and system performance.	Connected vehicle engineers must clearly disclose security risks and ensure safe system design before deployment.
BCS Code of Conduct	IT professionals must act responsibly and be answerable for their actions.	Promotes openness, honesty, and clear communication of technical issues.	Security researchers must transparently report vulnerabilities and manufacturers must communicate fixes and risks to users.

7 Conclusion and Personal Reflection

7.1 Conclusion

The Jeep Cherokee cyberattack is an indication of the extremely significant role of cybersecurity in the current automobiles. In this case, cybercriminals showed how cyber-attacks are not only related to computers but can impact the physical components of the car as well, including its braking and steering systems. It is shown in this case that cybersecurity in cars can be detrimental for their safety, privacy, and reliability.

It is also interesting to consider the case from the perspective of ethics and law associated with cybersecurity attacks on connected vehicles. There are many ethical perspectives that should be considered, including the ACM, IEEE, and BCS approaches.

7.2 Personal Reflection

Ethical considerations are equally very critical when dealing with cybersecurity-related decisions such as those involved in the incident with the Jeep Cherokee. For instance, it is essential for an ethical cybersecurity expert to adopt a systematic approach in making decisions in regards to such problems.

During brainstorming, all possible actions in terms of solving the problem may be explored; for example, testing the vulnerabilities of the system used, including the impacts that such tests may cause to the user. This will be followed by analysis, whereby ethical and technical concerns of the solutions may be identified, including the risk involved in using the system, laws and limits, as well as ethical codes.

Next, stakeholders may be identified, whereby they are individuals who are affected by the decision to be made, including users, automobile manufacturers, researchers, and regulatory organizations. Finally, consequences of each option or action are examined, including benefits or losses resulting from the actions, laws, and impacts.

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